

Word family: **detail / details / detailed / detailing**

Base word: detail

Plural: details

Past tense: detailed

Past participle: detailed

** -ing form:** detailing

Related form: detailed

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / adjective-related form (相關形容詞)

Your sentence:

> “He loves talking about old Hong Kong, unusual people he interviewed, books, films, and the tiny **details** that most of us walk straight past.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **details** means **small individual features, facts, or aspects of something that may easily be overlooked**.

The speaker means that Mr. Wong notices small things in everyday life that most people do not pay much attention to.

繁體中文： ** **構成整體事物的小部分、細微特徵或具體事項，通常需要仔細觀察才會注意到**

中文翻譯：

> “...the tiny **details** that most of us walk straight past.”

「.....那些大部分人會直接忽略的細小**細節**。」

Here:

detail = 構成一個較大整體的細小特徵、部分或具體事項

1. **detail = small feature/fact/aspect (細小特徵 / 事項) — 細節；細微之處**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A small individual feature, fact, or part of a larger whole.

Practice 1 — Original

> “He notices the tiny **details** that most of us walk straight past.”

「他會留意那些大部分人都會直接忽略的細小**細節**。」

Practice 2

> “She noticed every small **detail** in the painting.”

「她注意到畫中的每一個小**細節**。」

Practice 3

> “The designer paid close attention to the **details**.”

「設計師非常重視各種**細節**。」

****detail = 構成整體的一個細小部分、特徵或具體事項****

Common examples:

- * small detail
- * tiny detail
- * important detail
- * visual detail
- * design detail
- * background detail

These remain one underlying sense even when the context changes.

2. ****details = specific information (具體資料 / 資訊) — 詳情 ; 具體資料****

This is a very common plural use.

****Meaning:**** Particular facts or pieces of information about a situation, plan, event, person, arrangement, etc.

Practice 4

> “Please send me the **details** of the meeting.”

「請把會議的****詳情 / 具體資料****傳給我。」

Practice 5

> “We have not yet received the full ****details**** of the plan.”

「我們尚未收到這項計劃的完整**詳情**。」

****details = 關於某件事情的具體資料、事實或安排內容****

Typical expressions:

- * contact details
- * personal details
- * payment details
- * meeting details
- * booking details
- * further details

This is closely related to Meaning 1, but for learners it is useful to distinguish:

- > ****a detail**** = one small feature or fact
- > ****the details**** = the specific information about something

I would keep it as a separate practical sense because the usage pattern and Chinese interpretation are quite distinct.

3. ****in detail / go into detail (程度) — 詳細地 ; 深入說明****

Here, ****detail**** appears in a fixed grammatical construction.

Practice 6

- > “She explained the process ****in detail****.”

「她****詳細地****解釋了整個過程。」

Practice 7

- > “I don’t want to ****go into detail**** about what happened.”

「我不想****詳細講述****發生了甚麼。」

****in detail = 以很多具體資料和細小事項來說明，而不是只作簡略概述****

****go into detail = 進一步詳細說明某件事情****

I would treat this as an important fixed-expression extension rather than another core lexical meaning.

The Golden Manual explicitly says common fixed expressions should be included when they are useful, but should not automatically be turned into separate meanings if the core concept remains the same.

4. **detail + information/story/process (動詞)** — 詳細說明 ; 列明

As a verb, **detail** means to provide the specific facts or particulars of something.

Practice 8

> “The report **details** the causes of the accident.”

「報告**詳細**列出了 / 說明了**這宗**意外的成因。」

Practice 9

> “She **detailed** the steps needed to complete the project.”

「她**詳細**說明了**完成**這個項目所需的步驟。」

detail something = 逐項提供某件事情的具體資料、事實或步驟

This is a genuinely different grammatical function from the noun.

5. **detail someone to + duty/task (人員 / 任務)** — 指派 ; 派遣

This is another verb meaning, especially in military, police, security, or formal organizational contexts.

Meaning: To assign someone to a particular duty or task.

Practice 10

> “Two officers were **detailed to guard** the entrance.”

「兩名警員被**指派**負責守衛**入口**。」

Practice 11

> “Several soldiers were **detailed for** night duty.”

「幾名士兵被**指派執行夜間勤務**。」

****detail someone to/for a duty = 正式指派某人負責某項特定任務或工作****

This is clearly different from:

> “The report detailed the problem.”

So it deserves a separate meaning.

Register:

****formal / military / police / official****

6. ****detail a vehicle (車輛美容) — 精細清潔及護理****

This is a common modern service/business use, especially in North American English.

****Meaning:**** To thoroughly clean, polish, and restore the interior and/or exterior appearance of a vehicle.

Practice 12

> “I had my car ****detailed**** before selling it.”

「我賣車前找人替汽車做了****全面精細清潔及美容護理****。」

Practice 13

> “The shop specializes in ****detailing**** luxury cars.”

「這間店專門為豪華汽車提供****汽車美容及精細清潔服務****。」

****detail a car = 對汽車內外進行非常仔細的清潔、打理、拋光及外觀護理****

This is established modern English and distinct enough to include as a practical domain-specific sense.

The Golden Manual allows common specialist meanings when they are established and useful to ordinary learners.

Related form: ****detailed****

****Detailed**** means containing or providing many specific facts, features, or pieces of information.

Practice 14

> “She gave us a ****detailed explanation****.”

「她向我們作出了****非常詳細的解釋****。」

Practice 15

> “The map is extremely ****detailed****.”

「這張地圖的資料和細節非常****詳盡****。」

****detailed** = 包含大量具體資料、細節或細小特徵的；詳盡的******

This directly develops from the “specific particulars” family.

Important distinction: ****detail vs details****

This is especially important.

****a detail****

usually means one particular small feature or fact.

> “I noticed one interesting ****detail****.”

「我留意到一個有趣的****細節****。」

****details****

very often means the specific information about something.

> “Send me the ****details****.”

「把****詳情 / 具體資料****傳給我。」

So:

****detail** = 一個細節******

****details** = 關於某件事的詳情 / 具體資料******

The plural can shift the natural Chinese meaning substantially.

Important distinction: **detail vs information**

information

is the broad category of knowledge or facts.

> “I need more information.”

「我需要更多資料。」

details

usually means the specific particulars within that information.

> “I need the details.”

「我需要那些具體詳情。」

So:

information = broad information

details = specific facts or particulars

Important distinction: **detail vs fact**

A **fact** is something true or believed to be true.

A **detail** is a relatively small or specific part of a larger picture.

> “The meeting starts at nine.”

This may be:

* a **fact**

* a **detail of the meeting**

But not every fact is naturally described as a detail.

The concept of **detail** depends on its relationship to a larger whole.

Important distinction: **detail vs example**

detail

= a small specific part of the thing itself

example

= an instance used to illustrate or demonstrate something

> “The colour of the door is a detail.”

> “This house is an example of Victorian architecture.”

Different functions.

Important distinction: **detailed vs specific**

detailed

means containing **many individual particulars**

> “a detailed report”

= 報告內容非常詳盡

specific

means exact, clearly identified, or particular rather than general

> “a specific reason”

= 一個明確、特定的原因

Something can be:

> **specific but not detailed**

For example:

> “The problem is the battery.”

That is specific, but not detailed.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **detail**

* **details**

* **detailed**

* **detailing**

Useful expressions and compounds include:

* **in detail**

* **go into detail**

* **attention to detail**

* **personal details**

* **contact details**

* **payment details**

* **car detailing**

attention to detail

= careful awareness of small features and accuracy

> “She has excellent **attention to detail**.”

「她非常**注重細節 / 對細節觀察仔細**。」

This is highly relevant to your original passage because Mr. Wong notices things other people overlook.

The Golden Manual says useful compounds and fixed expressions should be included when they add genuine learning value without falsely being treated as extra base-word meanings.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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detail — small feature/fact	構成一個較大整體的細小部分、特徵或具體事項	
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| **details — specific information** | 關於某件事情、安排、人物或計劃的具體資料和詳情
 |
in detail / go into detail	以很多具體資料和細小事項進行詳細說明
detail something — explain/list	逐項提供或說明某件事情的具體事實、資料或步驟
detail someone to/for duty	正式指派某人負責某項特定任務；常見於軍事、警務或正式語境
detail a vehicle	對車輛內外進行非常仔細的清潔、打理、拋光及外觀護理
detailed	包含大量具體資料、細節或細小特徵的；詳盡的
attention to detail	對細小特徵、準確性和具體事項保持高度留意和仔細處理的能力

For your original sentence

> “...books, films, and the tiny **details** that most of us walk straight past.”

The exact meaning is:

detail = 構成整體的一個細小特徵、部分或具體事項

More specifically:

tiny details = 日常環境中很細微、很容易被其他人忽略的小特徵或小事情

So:

> **the tiny details that most of us walk straight past**

= **那些大部分人會直接忽略的細微之處**

For your database, I would count **5 genuinely useful core polysemy/polyfunctionality meanings** for **detail**:

1. **a small feature/fact/part of a larger whole**
2. **details — specific information / particulars**
3. **verb — give or list specific information**
4. **verb — formally assign someone to a duty**
5. **verb — thoroughly clean and cosmetically maintain a vehicle**

I would treat **in detail**, **go into detail**, and **attention to detail** as important fixed expressions rather than inflate the core count.